

college and get established in her career. After that, they would begin a family. There was some thought that Ben might go back to college someday to finish up his degree, but that was only a vague idea.

But after living in an apartment for five months, Ben decided that it didn't make any sense to keep throwing money away on rent. Some of the guys at work had told him he was losing all the tax breaks the government allowed homeowners. "Get yourself a house and start building some equity," was their advice.

Ben and Naomi began to look for a house they could buy. They found one that was near their price range, but the bank wouldn't finance it on the basis of his income alone. So during the summer college break Naomi took a job with a local product design company, part-time so she could return to college. Based on their combined incomes, they signed to buy the home. With their credit card and store credit, they were able to furnish it and buy the appliances they needed. There was enough available credit on their card to enjoy nice dinners, evenings at the movies, and sporting events.

They didn't have the down payment, so Ben's dad cosigned for a loan through his credit union. The couple did not include this amount as a loan on their mortgage application. The monthly house payments required more than half of Ben's take-home pay at the time. Almost immediately they were in financial trouble from the payments alone. With the insurance, taxes, and utilities added, Ben and Naomi were on the road to debt without realizing it.

After the first month, Ben was unable to make the payment on the credit union loan. When it was sixty days delinquent, the credit union had the payments deducted automatically, according to their written agreement. Ben's father, the cosigner, was sent a written notice of collection proceedings against him for the two months in arrears. When he received the notice, he hit the roof and stormed over to Ben and Naomi's to confront the issue.